

Scrolling for an Ideal Self: Symbolic Consumption and Identity Construction in Chinese University Students' Study Plog Engagement on Rednote

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Introduction

In the age of digital media, university students in China are increasingly drawn to study plogs—photo blogs containing the act of studying. Shared widely on Rednote (also called Xiaohongshu, a Chinese social media platform), these plogs typically feature carefully composed images of notebooks, stationery, and study environment, often accompanied by motivational captions or productivity tips. However, study plogs increasingly present a homogenized, idealized aesthetic: coffee-shop studying, high-quality stationery, iPads, scented candles, and carefully arranged study spaces. These visual practices suggest that study plogs function as symbolic environments in which viewers interpret desirable lifestyles and identities.

This research focuses on study plog engagement among Chinese university students, focusing on its relationship with the concept of petite bourgeois fantasy. In this study, petite bourgeois fantasy refers to an aspirational imagination of a refined, disciplined, and culturally valued lifestyle pursued through symbolic participation rather than actual class transformation.

Specifically, it investigates how Chinese university students interpret the symbolic meanings embedded in study plogs on Rednote and how these interpretations relate to their understandings of identity, lifestyle, and consumption practices. By exploring audience reception rather than content production alone, this research contributes to a deeper understanding of how symbolic consumption operates in everyday digital practices and how young users negotiate aspirational identities through social media engagement.

Theoretical Foundation

Cultural consumption provides a framework for understanding how engagement with cultural representations and practices can carry social and symbolic meanings (Rössel et al., 2017). On

Rednote, viewing study plogs can therefore be understood as a form of cultural participation through which students encounter and interpret particular lifestyles, tastes, and social meanings.

Bourdieu's (1984) theory of distinction further explains why certain objects and lifestyles represented in study plogs are perceived as desirable. Cultural preferences and consumption practices often function as markers of social positioning. In this context, studying in aesthetically curated spaces, using particular stationery brands, or adopting specific productivity routines may represent more than personal preferences; they reflect culturally valued forms of taste and lifestyle aspiration.

Belk's (2013) extended self theory complements this perspective by explaining how objects, images, and digital representations can become connected to individuals' conceptions of self. In the context of study plogs, tablets, stationery, and curated study environments may therefore function not only as practical resources but also as symbolic resources through which viewers imagine an idealized version of themselves.

Together, these theoretical perspectives provide a framework for examining how students move from interpreting symbolic meanings in study plogs to negotiating identities and consumption practices. They trace a path from symbolic consumption to identity negotiation and aspirational practice.

Literature Review

Digital Visual Culture and Symbolic Meaning in Plog Practices

Recent studies have examined plog as a visual communication practice shaped by images, text, and lifestyle narratives. According to Wu (2021), plogs construct meaning through visual symbols and emotional narratives, forming a distinctive aesthetic system that combines images, text, and lifestyle expression. Wang and Xu (2023) emphasize that plogs on Rednote not only represent a record of learning habits but also a symbolic mapping of middle-class aesthetics and lifestyle values.

Existing research has primarily focused on how symbolic meanings are produced through plog content and visual composition. Audience-oriented studies, such as Zhang and Ma (2023), have

examined users' motivations and engagement patterns, but have paid less attention to how audiences interpret symbolic meanings embedded in plogs.

Research on Self-Presentation of Ploggers on Rednote

Another line of research examines how plog creators construct identities through visual self-presentation. Drawing on Goffman's dramaturgical perspective, scholars argue that plogs function as spaces where users manage impressions and present idealized versions of themselves. Wang (2022) further suggests that youth self-presentation on Rednote reflects negotiations of subjective class identity, indicating that digital performances are connected with broader social positioning.

Nevertheless, these studies overwhelmingly prioritize the creators' perspective. Few have examined how audiences interpret these performances and relate them to their own identities, aspirations, and practices.

Research on Symbolic Consumption and Aspirational Identity on Multimedia Platforms

Zhu (2021) demonstrates that lifestyle expression on Rednote transforms everyday practices and emotional narratives into symbolic resources associated with taste and identity. Skulsuthavong and Wang (2025) find that Chinese university students use symbolic consumption practices, such as adopting specific visual styles and purchasing aesthetic products, to negotiate desired identities and social positioning on social media. Together, these studies suggest that symbolic meanings on Rednote can become resources for identity negotiation. However, less is known about how these symbolic meanings are interpreted by audiences of study-oriented lifestyle content.

Research Gap and Specific Research Questions

Existing scholarship provides less insight into what happens after these symbolic performances are encountered by audiences. Although some studies examine the motivations, practices, and boundary management of study ploggers (Tian, 2024), they primarily treat plogging as a practice of content production. What remains unclear is how audiences decode these representations, connect them to socially valued lifestyles, and potentially translate those

meanings into aspirations and everyday practices.

This study therefore focuses on audience reception of study plogs, examining how Chinese university students decode lifestyle symbols, connect them to aspirational identities, and incorporate their meanings into consumption and everyday practices. The study advances the following research questions:

RQ1: How do Chinese university students interpret the lifestyle and identity meanings represented in study plogs?

RQ2: How do audiences interpret symbolic objects featured in study plogs and relate them to their own consumption practices?

RQ3: How does engagement with study plogs relate to students' identity construction and lifestyle aspirations?

By addressing these questions, this study seeks to develop a deeper understanding of how Chinese university students interpret symbolic meanings in study plogs and how digital consumption practices contribute to the construction of aspirational identities.

Method

This study employs semi-structured interviews to explore how university students interpret symbolic meanings they encounter in study plogs and connect them to their own identities, aspirations, and practices. Compared with structured interviews, this approach allows participants to describe their perceptions and experiences while maintaining consistency across interviews (Jamshed, 2014).

University students were selected because they represent a major user group of study plogs and are actively engaged in negotiating academic identity and lifestyle aspirations during a transitional stage of identity development (Li, Zhao, & Zhang, 2021).

Seventeen university students aged 18 to 22 (6 men and 11 women) who had experience viewing study plogs on Rednote participated in this study. Participants represented different grades and academic majors.

Sixteen participants were interviewed via Tencent Meeting, and one was interviewed in person at the university dormitory. Before each interview began, the purpose of the study was explained to participants and informed consent was obtained. All interviews were audio-recorded with permission, professionally transcribed verbatim, and anonymized. Interviews lasted between 25 and 40 minutes ($M = 30$). Data collection continued until no substantial new themes emerged. The interview guide included open-ended questions such as “What kind of study plogs immediately catch your attention?” and “What impact does watching this type of content long-term have on your understanding of an 'ideal' college life?” to elicit detailed responses.

Data analysis followed a three-level coding process, open coding, axial coding, and selective coding, based on the principles of grounded theory (Strauss & Corbin, 1990). NVivo 11 was used to organize and manage the interview transcripts and coding process.

Open coding involved line-by-line examination of the interview transcripts to identify recurring concepts related to participants' viewing experiences, interpretations of study plogs, and subsequent behaviors. This process generated 32 initial codes, including “Content Preference,” “Symbolic Value of Objects,” “Class Fantasy,” and “Purchase Study Tools.” These initial codes captured participants' reported perceptions, emotions, and behaviors and were subsequently grouped into broader categories.

Axial coding was then conducted through constant comparison to identify relationships among the initial codes (Strauss & Corbin, 1990). Related codes were organized into eight categories, which were further consolidated into four broader analytical categories: Usage Patterns, Content Appeal, Cultural Symbol Decoding, and Consumption & Behavioral Impact.

Finally, selective coding was used to examine relationships among the four axial categories and identify the central pattern emerging from the interview. Examples of coding are presented in Table 2, while the resulting axial categories are summarized in Table 3.

Table 2

Examples of open coding

Initial Code	Category	Representative Interview quotes
C1 Entertainment	B1 Emotional Need	“I don't watch this kind of study plogs when I'm relaxing like others do. I see it as a source of motivation and planning. “
C2 Immersive companionship		
C3 Learning		
C4 Motivation		
C5 Knowledge sharing	B2 Learning Support	“I clicked on the profile picture and then started watching series of movies and books. Later, as I delved deeper into it.”
C6 Time manage		
C7 Content preference	B3 Visual Aesthetic Preference	“The ones with a simpler cover, which are more related to my interests, I will click on to read.”
C8 Personal style		
C9 Picture preference		
C10 Title preference		
... ..		

Table 3*Axial Coding Categories*

Categorization	Conceptualization	Connotation
A1 Usage Patterns	B1 Emotional Need	Usage Patterns connect users' Emotional Need with Learning Support through platform engagement.
	B2 Learning Support	
A2 Content Appeal	B3 Visual Aesthetic Preference	Content Appeal reflects users' Visual Aesthetic Preference and Idealized Narrative Identification with media content.
	B4 Idealized Narrative Identification	
A3 Cultural Symbol Decoding	B5 Symbolic Value of Objects	Cultural Symbol Decoding interprets the Symbolic Value of Objects to fuel Stratified Lifestyle Imagination.
	B6 Stratified Lifestyle Imagination	
A4 Consumption &	B7 Consumption	Consumption & Behavioral Impact

Behavioral Impact	Motivation	contains both Consumption Motivation and Learning Practice Reconstruction.
	B8 Learning Practice Reconstruction	

The coding process was used to trace how participants moved from initial engagement with study plogs to symbolic interpretation and, in some cases, reported changes in consumption and learning practices. The relationships among these categories and their implications for identity construction are examined in the next section.

Findings & Discussion

The analysis of 17 semi-structured interviews identified a four-stage pattern in students' engagement with study plogs: usage patterns, content appeal, cultural symbol decoding, and consumption and behavioral impact. Students initially engaged with study plogs for emotional support, motivation, or learning strategies, but deeper engagement involved more than functional use. As they became attentive to particular visual aesthetics and aspirational narratives, everyday objects and study environments came to be interpreted as symbols of specific lifestyles and identities. For some of them, these interpretations extended into consumption choices and learning practices.

This process suggests that study plogs function not only as sources of academic information or motivation but also as spaces where students interpret and negotiate aspirational identities.

Answers to Research Questions

RQ1: How do Chinese university students interpret the lifestyle and identity meanings represented in study plogs?

Participants commonly described study plogs as representations of an orderly, disciplined, and desirable student lifestyle. Rather than focusing only on academic performance, participants often responded to the broader lifestyle presented through study environments, routines, and visual aesthetics. This interpretation also occurs within Rednote's highly visual and personalized media environment, where image-based content and algorithmic recommendation can facilitate repeated encounters with similar lifestyle representations. Such repeated exposure

provides a platform context in which aspirational imagery may become familiar and socially meaningful.

One participant stated, “I appreciate this lifestyle and want to live an orderly and disciplined life.” Another explained, “Sometimes I put myself in it, I think if it were me, I might not be able to complete as many tasks as they do, but usually I also imagine myself studying in a coffee shop or something like that.” This reflects Belk’s (2013) extended self process: participants were not evaluating creators’ productivity but appropriating the represented lifestyle to imagine possible selves, treating the curated study environment as a template they could put themselves into.

Coffee shops, organized desks, stationery, and digital devices were therefore interpreted beyond their practical functions, becoming associated with a broader image of an ideal student and a desirable way of living. Their significance lay in what they symbolized about the kind of person one could become.

RQ2: How do audiences interpret symbolic objects featured in study plogs and relate them to their own consumption practices?

Participants frequently interpreted objects featured in study plogs as indicators of taste, lifestyle, and economic capacity. One participant observed, “They often feature tablets, computers, and various stationery items, which are also related to economic conditions.” This reflects what Bourdieu (1984) terms distinction: the participant did not simply identify these objects as tools, but as markers of economic and cultural position.

Visual preferences also shaped participants’ engagement with plog content. One participant noted, “The ones with a simpler cover, which are more related to my interests, I will click on to read.”

For some participants, these symbolic interpretations extended into consumption practices. One participant explained, “Sometimes when I see what they post, if I like it very much, I will ask them for the link in the comment section and then buy it myself.” This illustrates how symbolic meanings could move from media representation into consumption, as the participant sought

not only the object itself but also the lifestyle meaning attached to its representation. Consumption here became a form of symbolic participation in an imagined lifestyle.

RQ3: How does engagement with study plogs relate to students' identity construction and lifestyle aspirations?

Engagement with study plogs could therefore function as a way of imagining an aspirational future self. One participant stated, "Watching study plogs increased my motivation. If I want a better quality of life in the future, I will work harder." Another explained, "I don't watch this kind of study plogs when I'm relaxing like others do. I see it as a source of motivation and planning." However, not all participants experienced this positively. One noted that constant exposure to idealized study routines sometimes made her feeling anxious about her future.

These responses show that participants could interpret study plogs as representations of a possible future self rather than simply as records of others' current study behavior. The imagined lifestyle was therefore not limited to academic achievement; it encompassed ways of living, consuming, and presenting oneself that participants associated with a desirable future identity. Rather than aspiring simply to study more effectively, participants were imagining a broader lifestyle associated with discipline, refinement, productivity, and material comfort. This distinction is central to the *petite bourgeois* fantasy examined in this study: participation in the symbols of a culturally valued lifestyle becomes a way of approaching an imagined social identity without necessarily involving actual changes in class position.

Significance

Unlike prior work that treats plogs primarily as content produced for display, this study shows that the symbolic meanings attached to studying are shaped through repeated exposure to digital media platforms, extending existing production-focused accounts to the reception side of the process. Drawing on these perspectives, the findings suggest that objects, environments, and routines represented in study plogs acquire symbolic meanings that allow students to imagine and approach aspirational identities.

Study plogs therefore do not simply promote products; they connect material objects to lifestyle

narratives and desired self-images. Such symbolic participation may allow users to approximate a culturally valued lifestyle through consumption and everyday practice, reflecting the petite bourgeois fantasy examined in this study. Consumption can consequently function as symbolic participation, allowing students to approach identities and lifestyles they find desirable.

Practically, these findings provide insights for digital communication and platform governance. Recognizing that young users invest in symbolic lifestyles suggests that media practitioners could engage audiences through aspirational narratives rather than purely functional messaging. At the same time, the findings suggest that repeated exposure to idealized visual representations may shape how users evaluate their own lifestyles, highlighting the importance of balancing aspirational communication with more realistic representations.

Limitations and Future Research

The study has several limitations. First, the findings are based on interviews with 17 university students who actively engage with study plogs on Rednote. This relatively small sample size limits the generalizability of the findings. Second, this study focuses on a single platform and a specific type of lifestyle content, meaning that the identified patterns may not fully represent symbolic consumption processes across other digital environments. Future research could examine larger and more diverse samples through quantitative methods or comparative studies across different platforms to further investigate how visual symbols influence identity construction and consumption behavior.

Conclusion

This study demonstrates that engagement with study plogs involves more than academic information or motivation. Through interpreting visual symbols, lifestyle narratives, and material objects, Chinese university students use study plogs to imagine and negotiate aspirational identities. The findings suggest that symbolic consumption on social media may operate less through the acquisition of isolated products than through participation in the lifestyles and identities those products represent.

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